Aquifer Open Study Notes

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Song of Songs

Song of Solomon 1:1

This verse gives the English title of the book. It acts as the title page, showing the genre (song) and linking to the likely author of some or all of the book (see Song of Songs Book Introduction, "Authorship"). The New Living Translation correctly sees "song of songs" as a Hebrew superlative. This means the song is the highest, best, or most sublime, likely making it more wonderful than any of Solomon's 1,005 songs (see 1 Kings 4:32).

Song of Solomon 1:2

- kiss me with the kisses of his mouth!: The woman desires the touch and taste of kisses from her true love. From the beginning, we see that the young woman and the man have a strong attraction. Their relationship is based on mutual respect and caring love.
- Love is a sensual experience in the Song. The taste of love is sweeter than wine, a rich and sensuous liquid. Love, like wine, also makes the person who experiences it feel slightly light-headed.

Song of Solomon 1:2–14

- The song starts with the woman expressing her desire to be close to the man she loves. In the song, the woman often begins the relationship. The chorus, called the "Young Women of Jerusalem" in the New Living Translation, supports her choice of this man.
- According to a three-character dramatic interpretation, the song begins by describing the woman's situation. The king is about to bring her into his palace, but she truly loves her shepherd. She hopes her lover will save her from the king (Song of Solomon 1:4).

Song of Solomon 1:3

- The man's cologne smells sweet, suggesting the woman wants to be closer to him.
- the maidens adore you: His appeal is not just physical; he has a great reputation. The chorus of women shows their respect and admiration for him in Song of Solomon 1:4. By noting the attention he gets from other women, the woman shows her love is thoughtful. She feels lucky to be the one he loves back.

Song of Solomon 1:4

- Take me away: The two lovers are very active throughout the Song, traveling through the hills, to the city, and out to the country. This time, the woman invites the man to take her away with him and urgently expresses her desire to run. According to the three-character dramatic view, they might be running to escape the king, who has brought the young woman into his palace.
- May the king bring me to his chambers (literally into his rooms): A common interpretation is that the woman anticipates an intimate relationship with King Solomon. However, while a literal Hebrew translation indicates she has been brought into Solomon's rooms, it does not specify which rooms or imply it was her personal desire.
- The text shifts here from the second person ("you") to the third person ("his"), which might suggest two different men are involved—one being spoken to, the other being spoken about. In that case, the woman might want to run because she does not wish to be the king's concubine.
- If the Song is a collection of love songs without a narrative thread, it is not problematic for the lover to be identified here as the king and later as a shepherd (for example, Song of Solomon 1:7):

1. The language may or may not be intended literally
2. These titles, which are similar to other ancient Middle Eastern love poetry, may reflect the woman's view of her lover at a particular time (for example, by indicating that he is a king in her eyes)
3. Different poems may refer to different couples

- The woman frequently addresses the young women of Jerusalem (for example, Song of Solomon 2:7; 3:5). They are portrayed as close, trusted friends who are fond of the woman and respond to her requests. She often tells in them about her lover, and they praise the couple from their outside perspective (for example, Song of Solomon 5:1, 9).
- O king, from the New Living Translation, is not in the Hebrew. Its addition reflects the view that the young man is the king rather than a shepherd.

Song of Solomon 1:5–6

- The woman's dark skin is not related to her race; the sun has darkened her complexion. Despite this, she maintains her self-respect and asserts her beauty. She looks healthy from working in vineyards and caring for goats (see also Song of Solomon 1:8).
- Solomon had caretakers for his fields, vineyards, herds, and flocks; the herders lived in dark tents made of goats' hair.

Song of Solomon 1:5–11

If the Song is a three-character drama and the shepherd is her lover, the couple was apart while she was in the king's palace. In this passage, she wants to know where to find him when she leaves. Twice, she is frantic about losing him again (Song of Solomon 3:1–4; 5:2–8). At other times, her concern is more subtle (Song of Solomon 2:14).

Song of Solomon 1:6

- of the vineyards: The New Living Translation sees vineyard as a metaphor for the woman's body (compare Song of Solomon 2:15; 7:12). In ancient Near Eastern societies, brothers protected their sisters from early intimate relationships. The woman's protest shows she believes she is ready for love (see also Song of Solomon 8:8–12, the only other mention of the brothers).
- The dramatic view sees vineyard as actual vineyards: The brothers' mistreatment led to the woman's inability to care for the vineyards she was responsible for. She ended up in Solomon's harem because she could not pay him the money she owed (Song of Solomon 8:11–12).

Song of Solomon 1:7–8

- pasture your sheep: In this dramatic view, the woman's lover and his friends are actual shepherds. This is not a job or group you would link with King Solomon at any point in his life.
- like a veiled woman: Prostitutes wore veils to hide their identities (Genesis 38:14–16). Since Solomon has claimed the woman as a concubine, she has a reason to cover herself and stay discreet. She wants to avoid asking everyone around her where her loved one is (Song of Songs 3:3; 5:6–7). She wants to find him privately during the noon rest period so they can enjoy their time together.

Song of Solomon 1:8

- The man's first words in this poem gently calm the woman's anxiety by telling her where to meet him.
- The man wants to be with her and asks her to come disguised as a goatherd, following his flock's path.

Song of Solomon 1:9

- The shepherd often calls the woman "darling" (literally companion) to show his respect for her as a partner, friend, and lover (Song of Solomon 1:15; 2:2, 10, 13; 4:1, 7; 5:2; 6:4).
- In the ancient Near East, a charge of horsemen on stallions was sometimes stopped by releasing a mare in heat. This distracted the attacking horses and broke the charge. Similarly, the woman's beauty distracts other men.

Song of Solomon 1:10–11

The woman's beauty shines with her jewelry. The man decides to give her more jewelry to enhance her beauty even further (compare Matthew 13:12).

Song of Solomon 1:12

- The meaning of the word translated as table is unclear. The word "lying," as in the New Living Translation, is not in the Hebrew text. The king and the woman could be lying on a couch or bed, or they might just be sitting at a table in a palace room.
- The view that considers the Song as a collection of love songs does not focus on whether the man is actually a king.

Song of Solomon 1:12–14

- In the dramatic view, the woman is in the king's palace (Song of Solomon 1:4, 12), but her heart belongs to her shepherd lover (1:13–14).
- In the anthology view, this is a short poem about intimate fragrances.

Song of Solomon 1:13

- Myrrh comes from the branches of a fragrant shrub that did not grow in Israel. It was imported from Arabia and India at a high cost. The sachet is a small packet of sweet-smelling myrrh. The woman shows her desire for intimacy by comparing her lover to the sachet lying between her breasts.
- According to the three-character dramatic view, the woman is with the king in one of his palace rooms. However, the fragrance of myrrh between her breasts reminds her fondly of her shepherd lover, who is closer to her heart than the king.

Song of Solomon 1:14

- The woman deeply desires her man's true love, just as a traveler craves water at En-gedi, an oasis near the Dead Sea.
- Henna is a fragrant shrub from the En-gedi area; its blossoms were used to make red hair dye.

Song of Solomon 1:15

The comparison of the woman's eyes to doves (see also Song of Solomon 4:1; 5:12) is unclear. The metaphor might refer to their color or a gentle expression.

Song of Solomon 1:15–2.7

The couple lovingly describe each other. They admire her unique beauty and appreciate his strong protection and support.

Song of Solomon 1:16–17

- The soft grass is our bed. The beams of our house are cedars; our rafters are fragrant firs: The lovers imagine their luxurious surroundings of grass and overhanging trees as their house. She does not need the royal, palatial surroundings of a king because these God-created natural surroundings are more than enough for her and her true lover.
- In several poems, the countryside is a place of happy intimacy. The man and the woman make their bed outdoors and enjoy each other's company.

Song of Solomon 2:1–2

- a lily of the valley: The Hebrew text shows the woman's modesty and humility. She sees herself as just one flower among many in Sharon and the wide valleys of Israel.
- The man agrees with her comparison to a lily but says her beauty is rare; she is a lily among thistles.
- my darling (literally my companion): They are in love and also friends.

Song of Solomon 2:1–7

- In this short poem, the man and woman exchange compliments. They use flower and tree metaphors to describe their loving relationship. The man is the protector and provider,
- The poem ends (Song of Solomon 2:6) with the man and woman in an intimate embrace.

Song of Solomon 2:3

She is like a small, beautiful flower, while he resembles a large, strong apple tree. In the ancient Near East, an apple tree symbolizes sensuality due to its tasty fruit and pleasant fragrance. In the intense heat of the Middle Eastern climate, a tree's shade is not just refreshing; it can be life-saving (compare Jonah 4:6; Matthew 13:32).

Song of Solomon 2:4

- He has brought me to the house of wine: The woman now describes the man as her provider at a feast, leaving behind the image of the apple tree.
- his banner over me is love: He enjoys telling others how much he loves her.

Song of Solomon 2:5–6

- The woman's love is intense, and his love is overwhelming.
- If the Song is a collection of poems, the couple may be married. Their lovemaking is so exhausting that she feels faint and asks for raisin cakes and apples. In the ancient Near East, people considered these foods to be aphrodisiacs.
- sustain me: She now relies on him to revive her with fruit from the earlier image—he is the apple tree, so he can provide apples to renew her strength.
- His left hand is under my head: He tenderly supports her with his embrace as they lie together (see also Song of Solomon 8:3).

Song of Solomon 2:7

- I adjure you by the gazelles and does of the field: This plea is important in the Song; it repeats in Song of Solomon 3:5 and 8:4. A promise is requested, and witnesses were needed. The wild animals were the only witnesses present. These graceful animals suggest a romantic pastoral setting.
- Do not arouse or awaken love until the time is right: As in Song of Solomon 8:8–9, virginity is praised. The woman warns the women of Jerusalem to be cautious and not rush into love.

Song of Solomon 2:8–10

- The man eagerly wants to be with the woman. He finally reaches his lover's home and takes her to the romantic countryside during the fresh spring.
- The woman compares the man to a gazelle, a fast and graceful animal that easily overcomes obstacles to reach its goal.

Song of Solomon 2:8–17

In this poem, the woman looks forward to her lover's arrival. She describes winter ending and spring beginning, a time of floral scents and new starts. She and her lover are in their country garden, a place of closeness, though there is a hint of danger even here (Song of Solomon 2:15).

Song of Solomon 2:10–13

In the Middle East, winter is the rainy season with clouds, gloom, and cold. After winter, when the rains end, the lively sights, sounds, and smells of spring boost romantic feelings.

Song of Solomon 2:14

- In the dramatic view, the couple plays hide-and-seek. She teases him, and he pleads for her to appear. Even playful separation frustrates him.
- The rocks symbolize the separation he wants to overcome to be with her.

Song of Solomon 2:15

- The foxes might symbolize threats to the relationship. These threats are not specified; they could be the usual ups and downs of love, rival suitors, or anything else that might prevent the couple from enjoying each other's company.
- In the dramatic view, the woman's role as a vinedresser is still relevant. She is likely instructing the vinedressers who managed her vineyard and received two hundred pieces of silver from her in Song of Solomon 8:12. The concern about catching the foxes may relate to the woman's personal interest in preserving the value of her vineyards. Eventually, she needs to pay Solomon the lease. If the foxes dig holes and damage the grapevines, she will incur more debt.

Song of Solomon 2:16–17

- be like a gazelle: The woman sees her lover as strong and fast like a gazelle. She describes his delay as if he is grazing in the countryside.
- Alternatively, the lover, like a gazelle, grazes among the lilies, which might represent the woman. This suggests their close relationship. The woman is often compared to a garden (see also Song of Solomon 4:12, 15–16; 5:1; 6:2).
- turn: Her desire to see him in the evening grows stronger by the hour.

Song of Solomon 2:16–3.5

In this dramatic scene, the woman is already apart from her lover and is terrified that she will not see him soon. One night, her worries push her out of bed to search frantically for him. She finds him and takes him to meet her mother.

Song of Solomon 3:2

- The poem partly describes a lover's determination to overcome all obstacles to be with their beloved.
- Since the women of Jerusalem are mentioned often (Song of Solomon 3:5), the city is likely Jerusalem. Searching all its streets and squares was a bold effort.
- The king of Israel would probably not be outside in the city at night. If he had his sixty-man entourage with him (Song of Solomon 3:7–8), she would find him easily. Instead, the woman seems to be looking for an ordinary man in everyday places.

Song of Solomon 3:3

- The watchmen in ancient towns or cities were like police. They enforced social customs and laws. Positioned on city walls, they watched for attacks and ensured that any traffic entering or leaving the city was safe.
- The woman may have been stopped because she was not a city resident and was unfamiliar. It was not appropriate for a woman to be out alone at night. This scene highlights the woman's strong desire for the man, as she ignored social rules and safety concerns.

Song of Solomon 3:6–11

- In the three-character dramatic interpretation, Solomon's humility and generosity are evident when he attends a wedding of a woman who chose a common shepherd's love over his. With Solomon there, this ordinary wedding becomes a grand ceremony.
- If the Song is an anthology, this poem seems to describe Solomon's wedding procession. People are amazed by the luxury of his carriage and the power of his entourage. This reflects the importance of marriage, similar to how expensive and beautiful wedding dresses and tuxedos do in modern weddings.

Song of Solomon 3:9–10

- King Solomon's carriage was made from materials that matched his wealth and power. It included the same costly Lebanese wood used to build the Temple (1 Kings 5:5–6).
- inlaid with love by the daughters of Jerusalem: Despite all his splendor, Solomon was admired and served with love, even by his servants.

Song of Solomon 3:11

This is the only clear mention of a wedding in the Song. The text calls the woman a "bride" in Song of Solomon 4:8–12 and 5:1.

Song of Solomon 4:1

- my darling (literally companion): The man is about to express his love with someone who is both his friend and lover (see also Song of Solomon 4:7).
- like a flock of goats streaming down Mount Gilead: Middle Eastern goats are very dark, often black. The woman's hair flows over and down her lighter veil.

Song of Solomon 4:1–5.1

- The marriage is now complete.
- This poem is the first "descriptive poem" in the book (see also Song of Solomon 5:10–16; 6:4–6; 7:2–8). Scholars often call these poems by the Arabic term wasf (meaning "description"). These poems are similar to songs sung at modern Arabic weddings. They are preludes to sexual intimacy. In describing physical beauty, they often start at the head and move downward.

Song of Solomon 4:2

each has its twin, and not one of them is lost: Her teeth are complete and symmetrical. In a time when dental care was not advanced, a woman with all her teeth was very special!

Song of Solomon 4:3

Pomegranates have a rosy look and are among the most abundant fruits in the Middle East.

Song of Solomon 4:4

A slender neck held high shows confidence, dignity, and beauty. The Tower of David is not mentioned elsewhere in the Bible.

Song of Solomon 4:5

Your breasts are like two fawns...grazing among the lilies: This means they are soft, firm, beautiful, and round.

Song of Solomon 4:6

After mentioning the breasts in the previous verse, the man's exclamation about hurrying to the mountain of myrrh and hill of frankincense shows his desire to be close to this beautiful woman.

Song of Solomon 4:8

Mount Amana, Senir, and Hermon are the three northernmost peaks in Israel. They are the highest points on the border with Lebanon. These peaks symbolize the couple's greatest joy, from which they sometimes must come down.

Song of Solomon 4:9

my sister: The man calls the woman his sister to highlight their loving companionship and his role as her protector. This may sound unusual today, but it does not imply an incestuous relationship. Ancient Near Eastern love poetry often uses the terms brother and sister to describe two people in love.

Song of Solomon 4:10–11

wine...perfume...honey and milk: The woman is compared to things that are smooth, sweet, and sensual. Her love and their kisses, surrounded by rich fragrances, bring the bridegroom close to ultimate joy.

Song of Solomon 4:12

a garden locked up, a spring enclosed, a fountain sealed: This statement about her purity and virginity highlights his unique and special status (see Proverbs 5:15 for similar imagery). The images of spring and fountain suggest the most private parts of a woman's body.

Song of Solomon 4:13–14

The man now describes the most beautiful and pleasurable place between his lover's thighs.

Song of Solomon 4:16

- Let my beloved come into his garden and taste its choicest fruits: Finally, the woman invites the man to join her and experience her fully.
- The man had poetically affirmed the woman's purity (Song of Solomon 4:12). However, she is now completely devoted to him, so she reveals her treasures and invites him into the garden.

Song of Solomon 5:1

- I have come to my garden...my myrrh with my spices...my honeycomb with my honey...my wine with my milk: When the man enters the garden, he discovers endless enjoyment. They are thrilled to finally experience the vast pleasure of intimacy.
- drink freely, O beloved: The young women of Jerusalem encourage the couple to fully enjoy their union. There is no guilt or shame in the deep pleasure between husband and wife.

Song of Solomon 5:2

- I sleep, but my heart is awake: This describes a dream well; she was asleep, but her emotions and mind were active.
- My beloved is knocking: "Open to me": In the ancient Near East, opening doors symbolized sexual activity (see also Song of Solomon 8:9). The man knocking and asking to enter suggests he seeks a sexual union. He waits for permission and does not assume.

Song of Solomon 5:2–6.3

- One verse earlier, the couple fully enjoys their intimate union. Now the woman feels the pain of sep-

aration. In the dramatic interpretation, the woman has been separated from the man twice before and has searched for him (Song of Solomon 1:4–7; 3:1–4). This last time, the separation occurs in her dreams—it is only a nightmare. Her dream seems to continue to Song of Solomon 6:3, given the natural flow of questions and answers between the woman and the young women of Jerusalem.
- If the Song is a collection of poems, these poems explore love rather than recounting actual events. This poem reminds us that an intimate relationship is not always easy or perfectly satisfying.

Song of Solomon 5:4–6

My beloved put his hand to the latch; my heart pounded for him: The man keeps trying to excite the woman, and she eventually responds positively. However, by the time she responds, he has either given up or become busy with something else. This is a strong poetic image of the challenges two lovers face in becoming intimate with each other.

Song of Solomon 5:7

- the watchmen…beat me and bruised me: The watchmen, who were protectors in Song of Solomon 3:3, now become threatening figures in her dream (Song of Solomon 5:2). Their actions reflect her feelings of being pummeled and wounded.
- They took away my cloak: She feels she has lost her dignity.

Song of Solomon 5:8

I am sick with love: The woman's trauma symbolizes her lovesickness (compare Song of Solomon 2:5).

Song of Solomon 5:8–9

The woman asks the young women of Jerusalem to help find her lover. They ask her to describe him, leading to the second descriptive poem (wasf) of the Song (see study note on Song of Solomon 4:1–5:1).

Song of Solomon 5:10

dazzling and ruddy: He looks very healthy and has a deep tan. This description does not refer to race; it likely shows good health and sun exposure.

Song of Solomon 5:10–16

This detailed description of the lover in the Song highlights his value to the woman.

Song of Solomon 5:11–15

The woman describes the man as a statue made of gold, ivory, lapis lazuli, and marble pillars. This suggests he looks god-like, as ancient statues of deities used these precious materials (Exodus 32:1–4; 1 Kings 12:28; Daniel 2:32233; 3:1).

Song of Solomon 5:13

His cheeks are like spice gardens because he had a full beard, common in his culture. This beard was likely perfumed.

Song of Solomon 5:14

- The man's body is shown as beautiful and valuable.
- Beryl is a green gemstone.
- Sapphire is a blue gemstone.

Song of Solomon 5:15

Lebanon is north of Israel and has famous cedar trees that are large, majestic, and have a pleasant fragrance.

Song of Solomon 5:16

The woman finishes by saying she wants to kiss him.

Song of Solomon 6:1–3

The conversation at the end of this poem shows it is not a real event. The dream ends when the young women of Jerusalem ask the woman where her man has gone. The woman tells them not to worry about finding him—he is back in bed with her, enjoying his garden with its spice beds and lilies, which describes sexual intimacy.

Song of Solomon 6:4

- Tirzah was a city-state as early as the time of Joshua. It eventually became significant enough to be the capital of the northern kingdom (Joshua 12:24; 1 Kings 15:33). The town's name means "pleasant."
- Jerusalem was the capital of the united kingdom of David and Solomon. After that, it remained the most important city of Judah.

Song of Solomon 6:4–10

The man describes the woman's physical beauty again. He repeats parts of the description from Song of Solomon 4 almost word for word, showing his high regard for his wife.

Song of Solomon 6:8–9

- If the Song were an allegory of the Lord's love for his people, it would be a weak comparison. Solomon's many marriages poorly represent God's love and faithfulness (see 1 Kings 11:1–13).
- sixty queens: Solomon married many wives through international treaties (see 1 Kings 11:1–3, 8).
- Concubines were wives with lower status than a primary wife but higher than a slave. People acquired concubines through war, debt repayment, or purchase.
- In the anthology view, mentioning queens and concubines means the woman is more desirable than all others.

Song of Solomon 6:9

sing her praises: Literally called her blessed. If the Song is a drama, the woman left Solomon's harem. The singing happened in the past, when she was still there.

Song of Solomon 6:10

The poem ends as it began in Song of Solomon 6:4: The woman's grandeur, like an army with waving banners, makes knees tremble and hearts race.

Song of Solomon 6:11

I went down: It is unclear who is speaking. The New Living Translation shows it as the young woman's speech, but it could also be the young man's. The trip to the walnut grove poetically expresses a desire for a romantic meeting.

Song of Solomon 6:12

among the royal chariots of my people: Desire leads to the union of a man and a woman. This may suggest Solomon is the husband, though it could also be a metaphor for the joys of romance (compare Song of Solomon 1:16–17).

Song of Solomon 6:13

- come back: Or turn around.
- Shulammite: The exact location is unknown, but some think it might be Shunem (1 Kings 1:3; 2 Kings 4:11–12). Maid of Shulam (Hebrew shulammith) could be a wordplay on Solomon's name (Hebrew shelomoh). It might mean "Solomon's maiden."
- as on the dance of Mahanaim?: The man praises the woman's grace and beauty to everyone.

Song of Solomon 6:13–7.9

The young women of Jerusalem talk with the man, leading him to describe the woman's beauty and express his wish to hold her (see study note on Song of Solomon 4:1–5:1).

Song of Solomon 7:1–5

- The man praises the woman's dancing feet and then admires her body up to her flowing hair (Song of Solomon 7:1–5).
- This daighter of the prince might not be from a royal family, but the man sees her as equal to royalty.

Song of Solomon 7:2

Your waist is a mound of wheat encircled by the lilies: The man is describing either the woman's smoothly rounded belly or her pubic area.

Song of Solomon 7:4

- pools of Heshbon by the gate of Bath-rabbim: The pools of Heshbon, created by a brook, are still visible today near the ruins of Heshbon on the east coast of the Dead Sea.
- the tower of Lebanon likely refers to Mount Hermon, a tall mountain overlooking the valley of Damascus, the capital of Syria. The woman's nose stands out beautifully among her facial features.

Song of Solomon 7:5–6

- Mount Carmel is a tall mountain range on the Mediterranean coast.
- the hair of your head like purple threads: Purple was expensive to make, so only royalty used it.

Song of Solomon 7:7–8

The husband talks about their intimate moments. He moves up her body and gently touches her breasts.

Song of Solomon 7:9

The man compares the woman's love and kisses to wine because they are delightful and make one feel dizzy (see Song of Solomon 1:2).

Song of Solomon 7:11–12

The woman suggests they visit the vineyards together to check their status and make love while there.

Song of Solomon 7:13

- Mandrakes (Hebrew duda'im) were a Middle Eastern plant used as an aphrodisiac (see Genesis 30:14–16).

The roots look like a human torso. The word is a play on "my lover" (Hebrew dodi).
- at our door: All sexual pleasures are now available to them, and she will share the delights she has saved just for him.
- new...old: She thinks about the sexual experiences they have already had and new ones they will try.

Song of Solomon 8:1

If he were her brother, she could kiss him in public. Romantic kisses were not appropriate in public, but kisses between family members were acceptable.

Song of Solomon 8:1–4

The woman wants to be with the man and in his arms.

Song of Solomon 8:2–3

bring you to the house of my mother: Compare Song of Solomon 3:4.

Song of Solomon 8:4

I adjure you: For the third time, the woman urges the young women of Jerusalem to keep their virginity (see Song of Solomon 2:7; 3:5). The importance of virginity is affirmed in Song of Solomon 8:8–9.

Song of Solomon 8:5

- I roused you under the apple tree: The apple tree symbolizes fertility because it bears fruit (see Song of Solomon 2:3, 5; 7:8).
- there your mother conceived you: Mentioning his mother subtly suggests procreation as a result of sexual love (compare Song of Solomon 8:2).

Song of Solomon 8:6

seal over your heart . . . on your arm: In ancient Israel a seal was used for identification or to show ownership by pressing the face of a ring into soft wax. The husband wants his wife to mark him with her identity, privately upon his heart, and publicly upon his arm as well. • love is as strong as death: Though death is inevitable, the bond of love is resolute, unshakable, and broken only in death. • The energy of jealousy moves to protect an exclusive relationship such as that of husband and wife or between God and his people (Nah 1:2; Zech 1:14–17). • as the grave: Hebrew as Sheol. In the Old Testament, Sheol is the abode of the dead. It is not necessarily associated with punishment.

Song of Solomon 8:8

We have a little sister: The wife's brothers worry about their sister's purity. In ancient Near Eastern culture, they protect their sister's sexuality until she marries.

Song of Solomon 8:8–10

During a heartfelt exchange of romantic compliments and promises, there is strong support for waiting until marriage for sexual activity.

Song of Solomon 8:9

- wall: This term has two metaphorical meanings:

1. A young girl's chest is flat like a wall (see Song of Solomon 8:10)
2. Until marriage, she should remain abstinent and strong like a wall

- build a tower of silver upon her: Towers served as lookouts to protect the city; a silver one would be more noticeable and strong. If the woman is already a wall, having kept her virginity, they will honor and support her decision.
- On the other hand, a swinging door suggests promiscuity. The brothers will make her control herself.

Song of Solomon 8:10

- I am a wall: The woman states she remained pure for marriage.
- like towers: The woman uses words of attractiveness (see Song of Solomon 4:4; 7:4, 8) and questions her brothers' view of her as immature.

Song of Solomon 8:11

- Baal-hamon is not mentioned elsewhere in the Bible. However, "Balamon" appears in later writings as a location in northern Israel; it might be the same place. \
- a thousand shekels of silver: The Old Testament mentions various types of shekels, so the exact value is unclear, but the vineyard was large.

Song of Solomon 8:11–14

- In the dramatic view, the wife's problem with the vineyard in Song of Solomon 1:6 is finally solved. She has collected the lease money from her vineyard in Baal-hamon, allowing her to pay Solomon and her hired workers.
- If the passage is purely poetic, its main message is that love cannot be bought, even by a powerful king like Solomon.

Song of Solomon 8:13

- The scene has shifted from the lease payment to the more familiar and pleasant gardens.
- my companions: It seems the wife is talking with her friends. Her husband feels jealous and wants her attention.

Song of Solomon 8:14

- Come away, my beloved: She asks him to follow her, and he chases her as fast as a gazelle (see Song of Solomon 2:8–10).
- mountains of spices: Compare Song of Solomon 4:6.